

DAY ONE • TEN DAYS OF PRAYER

From *Falling* Down to *Rising* Again

A meditation on Acts 1:1–3, Acts 9, and John 15:5



OPENING

The part of Paul's story we often miss.

You know Paul: his journeys, churches, letters, and suffering for Christ. Two thousand years later, his ministry still builds us up.

But one part is often missed. In Jerusalem, Paul preached and debated; opposition erupted, people sought to kill him, and believers sent him to Tarsus. Luke then records that the church enjoyed peace.

Saul then almost disappears from Acts. More than a decade of his life is compressed into a few verses. Surprisingly, that quiet season may have been the most important in shaping Paul — and us through his ministry.



“After His suffering, He presented Himself to them and gave many convincing proofs that He was alive. He appeared to them over a period of forty days and spoke about the kingdom of God.”

ACTS 1:3

Acts 1:1–3 establishes this truth as the foundation of everything we will see: the risen Christ appeared over forty days, continuing to teach and prepare His disciples. Paul’s story shows that He is still doing the same today.

Jesus did not stop working when He ascended. He continues to meet, call, and shape His people.

A man who knew much about God

Knowledge, discipline, zeal — and still no Jesus.

A man who knew much about God — but did not know Jesus.

From the outside, Saul seemed very close to God. He had studied under Gamaliel, understood the Scriptures, lived by the strict demands of the law, and was deeply zealous for his faith. He was so serious about religion that he travelled from city to city to defend what he believed was right. When he set out for Damascus, he carried letters from the high priest authorising him to arrest the followers of Jesus and bring them back to Jerusalem.

WHAT SAUL HAD

Knowledge of Scripture

Discipline under the law

Zeal for God

A mission he believed was from God

But he did not know Jesus.

A person can know many things about God and still not truly know Him. Revival begins not with more information, but with a personal encounter.

When the risen Christ called Saul by name

Not Saul seeking Jesus — Jesus seeking Saul.

A light from heaven. A voice. A question.

THE VOICE

“Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting Me?”

SAUL

“Who are You, Lord?”

THE ANSWER

“I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting.”

ACTS 9:4–5

This may be the central question of Paul's entire life. Saul thought he knew God. He thought he was fighting for God. But when the living Jesus met him, Saul discovered that zeal and knowledge could not replace a genuine relationship with the Lord.

If Jesus were only a figure from the past, He could not have stopped Saul.

He could not have called him by name. He could not have exposed what was wrong within him. He could not have opened the way to a new life. But Jesus is alive. The One who appeared to His disciples over forty days also appeared to Saul.

The One who had taught and prepared the apostles continued to intervene in the life of a man heading in the wrong direction. Acts does not merely record what the apostles did for Jesus; it shows the risen Christ continuing to work in and through people.

Our hope is not found in Saul's fall. Our hope is found in the One standing before him — the living Jesus.

He did not leave Saul on the ground

Jesus came not to crush Saul, but to raise him.

“Brother Saul” — the Lord who sends a disciple.

“Go, for this man is My chosen instrument to carry My name before the Gentiles, their kings, and the people of Israel.”

ACTS 9:15 · THE LORD TO ANANIAS

Jesus saw a man whom Ananias could not yet see. In the eyes of many believers, Saul was still their persecutor. But Jesus saw someone whom His grace would transform. Ananias went, placed his hands on Saul, and called him “Brother Saul.” Something like scales fell from Saul's eyes. He could see, stood up, was baptised, ate, and regained his strength.

Six movements of grace.

I

Met Saul while Saul was heading the wrong way.

II

Called Saul by name and confronted him with truth.

III

Sent a disciple to stand beside him.

IV

Restored Saul's sight and filled him with the Spirit.

V

Brought the persecutor into the community he had harmed.

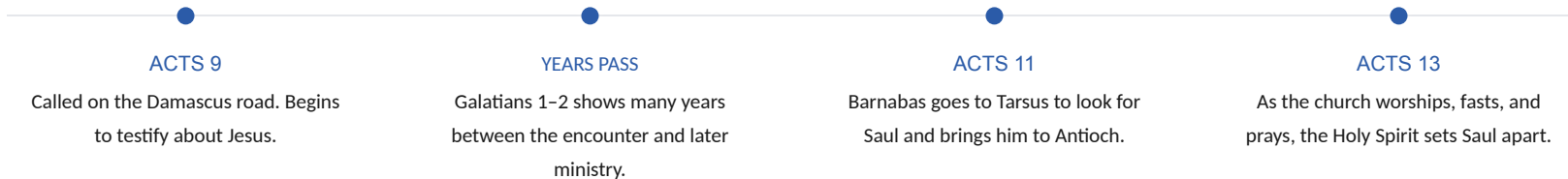
VI

Gave Saul a new direction and purpose.

He does not merely forgive the past. He creates a new future. He does not merely correct behaviour. He transforms people.

Before God worked through Paul, He worked in Paul.

Paul's calling was not formed in a single moment. God used time, community, and the guidance of the Holy Spirit to shape him.



“Set apart for Me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them.”

ACTS 13:2 · THE HOLY SPIRIT

Not only Paul

The same pattern echoes throughout Scripture.

Four witnesses. One shared truth.

I

Moses

Longed to deliver his people; God used wilderness years to teach him dependence on God's presence.

II

Peter

Genuinely loved Jesus but trusted his own strength; the risen Christ restored him and entrusted His flock to him.

III

Elijah

Exhausted even after a great victory; God met him in weakness, cared for him, and gave him his next assignment.

IV

Ephesus

Had deeds, hard work, perseverance — but Jesus called them back to their first love.

These stories are not identical. Yet they confirm a shared truth: God is not looking merely for activity, ability, or enthusiasm. He wants us to belong to Him, to be encountered by Him, and to be transformed by Him.

“*I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever remains in Me, and I in him, bears much fruit; for **apart from Me you can do nothing.**”*

JOHN 15:5

A branch does not bear fruit by straining to prove it is alive. It bears fruit because it remains connected to the source of life. We cannot replace abiding in Jesus with knowledge about Him, or activity for Him, or even a past encounter with Him.

I · THROUGH HIS WORD

He meets us in Scripture.

II · BY THE SPIRIT

He speaks to us today.

III · THROUGH HIS CHURCH

He sends “Ananias” to stand beside us.

Where is Jesus meeting us today?

We may not meet Him in a blinding light as Paul did. But the One who met him is still alive, and He still takes the initiative to enter people's lives.

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- I *In the middle of a plan we are certain is right — asking whether we are truly listening to Him.*
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- II *In failure — not to condemn us, but to free us from confidence in ourselves.*
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- III *Through an “Ananias” — bringing healing, encouragement, and a way back into community.*
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- IV *In long service slowly becoming facts, habits, and responsibilities — no longer friendship with a living Friend.*
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- *“Do I know Him? Am I listening to Him and walking with Him?”*

- *“What does God want to transform in me?”*